Community waiting list within 18 weeks

Forecast for September 2026 · data through August 2026

The latest Community waiting list within 18 weeks result was 75.8%. For the next release, it is expected to worsen to 74.9%. The model components are mixed, but together imply a small deterioration. The current projection is off course for 78% by March 2027. Across providers, sustained favourable signals outnumber adverse ones (9 to 8).

LATEST · AUGUST 2026	FORECAST · SEPTEMBER 2026	ACTUAL
75.8%	**74.9%**	—
0.5pp above forecast	80% expected range 73.8%–75.9%	Not yet released
		Off course · 78% by March 2027

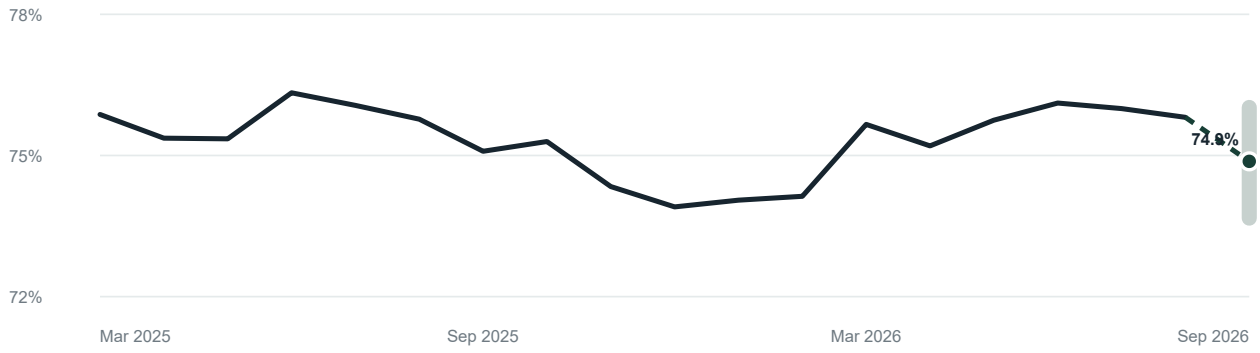
WHAT CHANGED?

Community waiting list within 18 weeks was broadly unchanged in the latest month. Total community waiting list changed by +15,513, while People within 18 weeks changed by +9,707. The percentage therefore reflects both the size of the cohort and how many were within the standard.

Monthly	Annual	Total community waiting list
-0.2pp	+0.0pp	+15,513

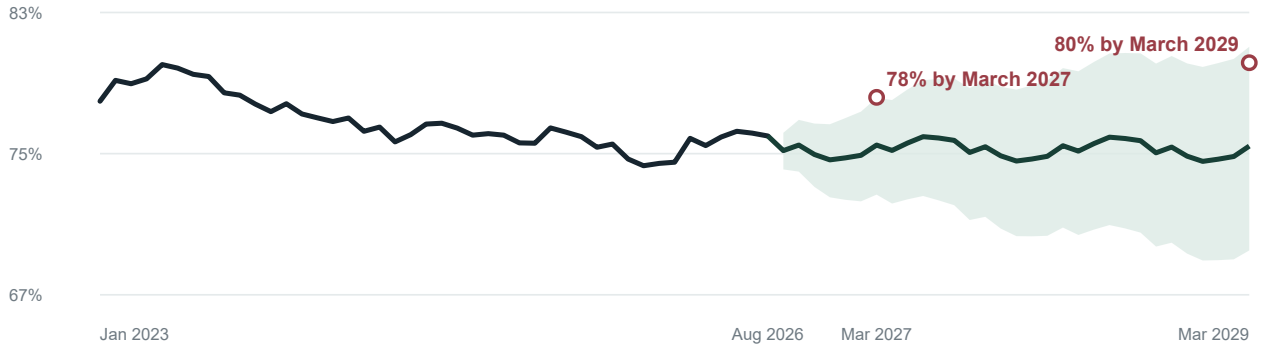
Recent performance and next release

The vertical band is the 80% expected range.



Longer-term outlook and milestones

Descriptive projection; not forced to meet targets.



Benchmark: 80% by March 2029. 2.8pp below milestone

Data: NHS England community health services waiting lists. **Targets:** Medium Term Planning Framework interim target · Medium Term Planning Framework final target

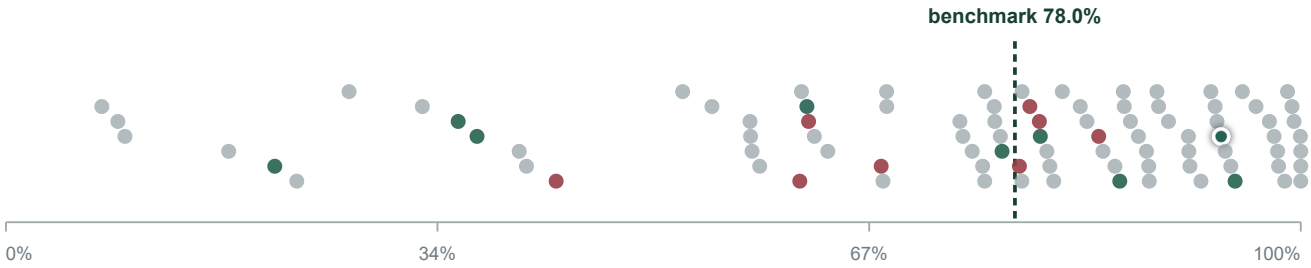
Method: Backtest-weighted ensemble of current-level seasonal movement, damped annual drift and a damped recent seasonal trend; at least 2 components are required. The final fit uses 44 consecutive months. Accuracy is tested on 12 rolling one-month-ahead forecasts. The 80% range uses empirical historical error quantiles from 12 forecast errors. Weights use inverse rolling RMSE and are shrunk toward equal weights. The pre-release commentary compares the current-level seasonal component with the combined forecast. Provider distribution and trajectory watch are shown on page 2.

Community waiting list within 18 weeks

Distribution and trajectory watch · August 2026

Provider distribution

Latest reported performance across providers. This is a comparison of current levels, not a measure of whether each provider is improving or deteriorating.

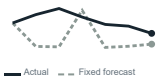


Trajectory watch

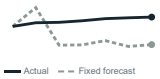
Six actual months are compared with one forecast path fixed before that window. Both lines begin at the same observed value. A low performer can be improving, while a high performer can be deteriorating. Status: Actual performance is compared with the monthly path forecast six months earlier. The displayed figure is the average gap across those six months.

48	9	8	31
providers assessed	sustained favourable	sustained adverse	without an active signal

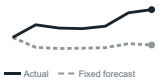
Largest sustained favourable moves

DONCASTER AND BASSETLAW TEACHING HOSPITALS NHS FOUNDATION TRUST
Latest 36.6% · 6 months compared with a path fixed six months earlier
Forecast fixed before the six-month window


44.3pp
BETTER THAN FIXED PATH

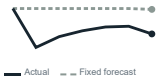
UNIVERSITY HOSPITALS PLYMOUTH NHS TRUST
Latest 80.0% · 6 months compared with a path fixed six months earlier
Forecast fixed before the six-month window


16.8pp
BETTER THAN FIXED PATH

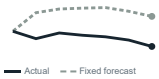
DERBYSHIRE HEALTHCARE NHS FOUNDATION TRUST
Latest 35.1% · 6 months compared with a path fixed six months earlier
Forecast fixed before the six-month window


14.1pp
BETTER THAN FIXED PATH

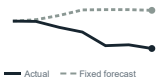
Largest sustained adverse moves

FRIMLEY HEALTH NHS FOUNDATION TRUST
Latest 79.9% · 6 months compared with a path fixed six months earlier
Forecast fixed before the six-month window


19.8pp
WORSE THAN FIXED PATH

WHITTINGTON HEALTH NHS TRUST
Latest 62.1% · 6 months compared with a path fixed six months earlier
Forecast fixed before the six-month window


14.7pp
WORSE THAN FIXED PATH

COUNTY DURHAM AND DARLINGTON NHS FOUNDATION TRUST
Latest 78.3% · 6 months compared with a path fixed six months earlier
Forecast fixed before the six-month window


6.3pp
WORSE THAN FIXED PATH

Trajectory-watch rule. Six actual months are compared with the corresponding path fixed before the six-month window. A signal requires a material average gap, at least five of six months in the same direction, and the latest month confirming that direction. These are screening prompts—not league tables, causal estimates or judgements of provider quality.

Community waits by service

England · August 2026

SERVICE MIX

Where waits over 18 weeks are concentrated

Services differ greatly in size. This ranks the published service categories by the number waiting over 18 weeks; it is a descriptive breakdown, not a forecast or provider comparison.

47

services with a reported total waiting list

43

services with complete published over-18-week bands

SERVICE	TOTAL WAITING	OVER 18 WEEKS	WITHIN 18 WEEKS
Community paediatric service	174,537	129,158	26.0%
Musculoskeletal service	456,532	78,025	82.9%
Therapy interventions: Speech and language	58,114	20,122	65.4%
Podiatry and podiatric surgery	113,132	15,689	86.1%
Therapy interventions: Occupational therapy	19,992	6,015	69.9%
Nursing and Therapy support for LTCs: Continence/ colostomy	44,259	5,996	86.5%
Therapy interventions: Physiotherapy	49,316	5,406	89.0%
Therapy interventions: Dietetics	35,793	5,178	85.5%
Audiology	16,214	5,064	68.8%
Therapy interventions: Speech and language	28,297	4,710	83.4%
Rehabilitation services (integrated)	46,590	3,720	92.0%
Audiology	16,079	3,379	79.0%
Therapy interventions: Physiotherapy	20,054	2,688	86.6%
Neurorehabilitation (multi-disciplinary)	13,806	2,517	81.8%
Therapy interventions: Dietetics	8,354	2,091	75.0%

Coverage and interpretation. Ranked by the published number waiting over 18 weeks. Complete over-18 bands were available for 43 of 47 services with a reported total. Rows with suppressed or incomplete bands are excluded from the ranking. The national headline on page 1 remains the authoritative aggregate. The within-18-week percentage is total waiting less all published over-18-week bands, divided by total. NHS England notes that the sum of weekly bands may not match the total where some providers were still collecting waits by weeks; reconciliation differences are retained in the QA outputs.